had a long conversation with Ajit, and one challenge he put in front of me was to try to remain not out in both innings. He said that I was allowing myself to get out to bowlers, rather than making them have to take my wicket, and that if I decided to rein myself in, no bowler would be able to get me out. I took up the challenge and decided to play a waiting game. Even if I looked ugly in the middle I was intent on sticking to my plan. Having got out twice in the series playing aggressive shots, I was simply not going to try anything extravagant at the SCG. True to my promise, I played what was in some ways one of my most difficult Test innings. I consciously checked my shots and was determined not to get out. In more than ten hours at the crease I did not play a single cover drive. When the Australian bowlers cracked a few jokes at my expense, I remained focused. It was a real test. Even when balls were there for the drive, I let them go. It was all totally against my natural instincts and it left me drained but immensely satisfied. At the end of our first innings, I was not out on 241 and had taken the team score past 700.

When I think about this Test, I can’t help remembering that for some reason I turned unusually superstitious. Anjali, her parents, Sara and Arjun were with me on the eve of the match and we decided to go to a Malaysian restaurant for dinner. The food was excellent and we ended up ordering noodles, chicken and a host of other dishes. My family then left for India the next morning, but I had a very good first day and was unbeaten on 73. In the evening I decided to stick to the routine of the previous night and went to the same Malaysian restaurant, this time with Ajit Agarkar and a couple of other players. Not only did we sit at the same table, but I had exactly the same food. The next day went even better and I was not out on 220. That night, I again went to the same restaurant and occupied the same table and ate the same food. On the third day of the match, with the Test match going really well for us, we went to the same restaurant one final time. The restaurant manager must have thought we were mad. At the same time he must have been elated at the thought that we had returned because of the food. Little did he know the real reason for our fourth consecutive visit!

After my double century, I was sent to address the media. A local journalist said that I had been getting a lot of flak in the press recently but, now that I had scored an unbeaten double hundred, would I be reading the papers the following morning? All I said to him was that I